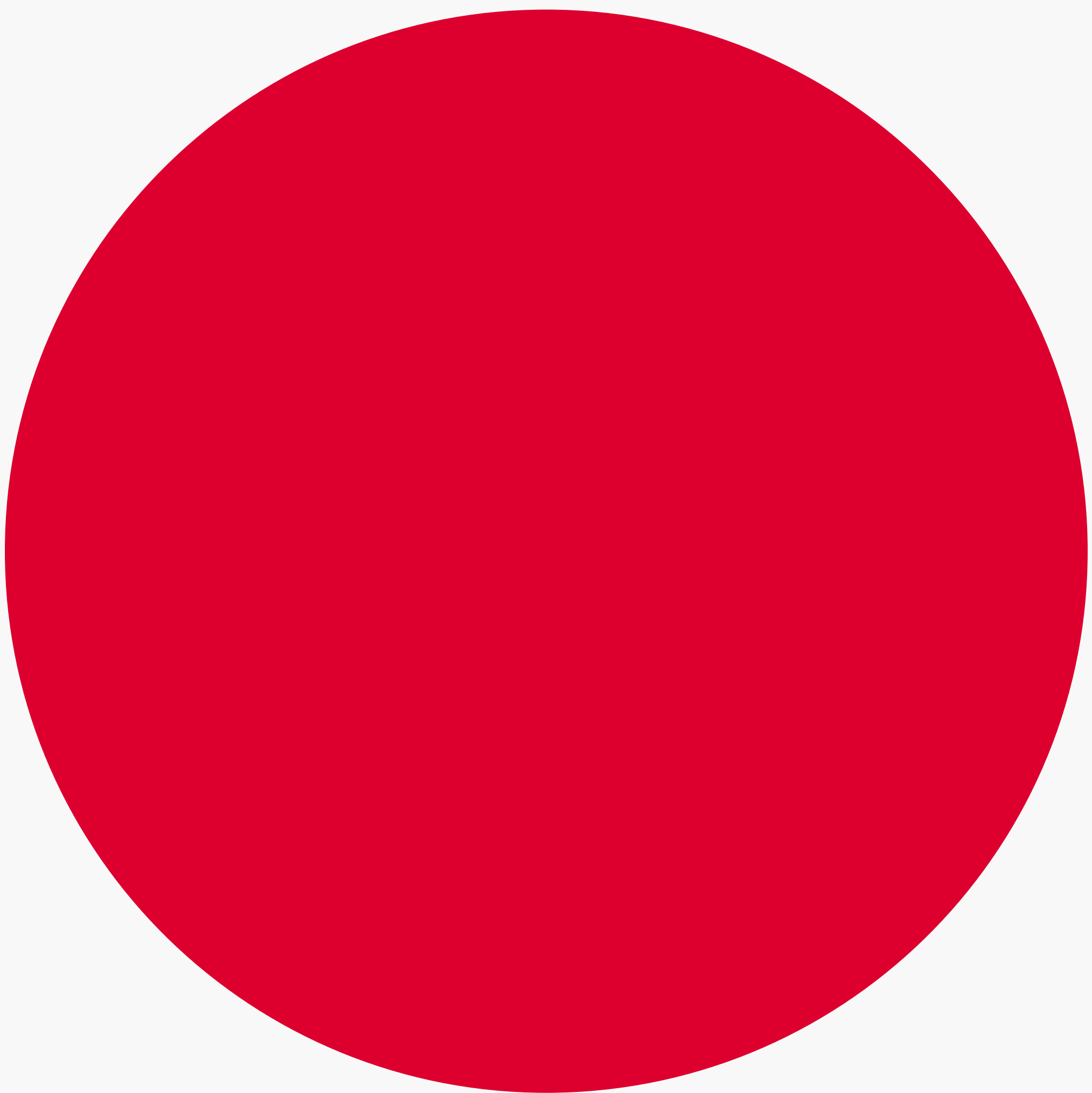


The Essential 30

Polite Japanese for Work



REAL-WORLD JAPANESE

Find your situation → Check "What NOT to say" → Pick A/B/C templates

- A** Casual (Peer)
- B** Work-Safe (Standard)
- C** Formal (Client / Boss)

How to Use This PDF

This pack is designed for one thing:

copy-paste Japanese that is safe at work.

1 Find your situation fast

- Use your PDF viewer's search for English keywords (e.g., "deadline", "review", "late", "follow-up", "disagree").
- Each entry is written in the same format so you can scan quickly.

2 Check "What NOT to say" first

Japanese can sound harsh if translated directly from English.

The "What NOT to say" line shows the common trap that can come across as blunt, demanding, or cold.

3 Pick your level (A / B / C)

- A (Casual — Peer): Teammates you're close with. Light internal chat.
- B (Work-Safe — Standard): Use this when unsure. The safest default inside a company.
- C (Formal — Client/Boss): External partners, executives, negotiations, or serious apologies.

4 Copy, then personalize

Copy the Japanese line and adjust only what you need:

- Add a name: 田中さん / ○○さん
- Add timing: 本日中午 / 明日までに / 今週中に
- Add the ask / deliverable: ご確認 / ご共有 / ご相談

Two important notes

- Send Japanese only: Romaji is for pronunciation practice. In real messages, paste Japanese text only.
- Don't over-explain: In Japanese business style, it's often better to keep it short and offer the next step ("If Friday works, I can deliver.").

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- 02 Invitation — lunch / drinks
- 03 Deadline — too tight / unrealistic
- 04 Out of scope — not my responsibility
- 05 Risk — risky / policy

2 Requests (依頼)

- 06 Review request — review / check
- 07 Information request — file / info
- 08 Quick consultation — 5 minutes / chat
- 09 Support / collaboration — help / support
- 10 Permission / PTO — day off / leave early

3 Apologies (謝罪)

- 11 Running late — late / train delay
- 12 Mistake / typo — typo / wrong number
- 13 Late reply — late reply / sorry
- 14 Missed deadline — missed deadline / by when
- 15 Forgot attachment — attachment / resend

4 Follow-ups (催促・確認)

- 16 No reply follow-up — follow-up / nudge
- 17 Clarification — clarify / align
- 18 Decision follow-up — decision / what was decided
- 19 Confirmation of receipt — did you get it? / receipt
- 20 Next action follow-up — next steps / action items

5 Opinions (意見・会議)

- 21 Disagree — disagree / different view
- 22 Raise a concern — concern / heads-up
- 23 Alternative proposal — suggestion / alternative
- 24 Pending / take it back — I'll get back / check internally
- 25 Interjecting — quick question / interrupt

6 Daily / Chat (雑談・日常)

- 26 Greetings (start/end) — good morning / signing off
- 27 BRB / away — away / back at
- 28 Gratitude — thanks / appreciate
- 29 Small talk (weekend) — weekend / how was it?
- 30 Encouragement — great job / don't overdo it

 **Tip: Use your PDF viewer's search with the keywords above**
(e.g., "deadline", "review", "late", "follow-up", "disagree").

01 Saying No

Capacity

Situation

A coworker asks you to take an extra task, but you're already overloaded.

Intention (what you mean)

I'd love to help, but I'm busy now. Later this week is fine.

⚠ What NOT to say (too direct)

無理です。忙しいです。
No, I can't. I'm busy.

A Casual (Peer)

今ちょっと手がいっぱい、難しいかも。来週なら見れるよ。
Ima chotto te ga ippai de, muzukashii kamo. Raishuu nara mireru yo.

B Work-Safe (Standard)

すみません、今ちょっと手がいっぱい、難しいです。来週なら対応できます。
Sumimasen, ima chotto te ga ippai de muzukashii desu. Raishuu nara taiou dekimasu.

C Formal (Client/Boss)

申し訳ありません、現状手がいっぱい、難しいです。来週であれば対応可能です。
Moushiwake arimasen, genjou te ga ippai de muzukashii desu. Raishuu de areba taiou kanou desu.

💡 Rule of thumb

In Japanese, "No" is often too sharp. Use "Muzukashii" (difficult) instead.
Always offer a specific alternative timeline to show you are willing to help.

02 Saying No

Invitation

Situation

You are invited to lunch or drinks, but you have other plans or just want to go home.

Intention (what you mean)

Thanks for asking, but I can't go today. Maybe next time!

⚠ What NOT to say (too direct)

行けません。予定があります。
No, I have plans.

A Casual (Peer)

誘ってくれてありがとう！今日は予定があって行けないんだ。また今度誘って！
Sasotte kurete arigatou! Kyou wa yotei ga atte ikenain da. Mata kondo sasotte!

B Work-Safe (Standard)

お誘いありがとうございます。今日はあいにく予定がありまして。またの機会にお願いします。
Osasoi arigatou gozaimasu. Kyou wa ainiku yotei ga arimashite. Mata no kikai ni onegai shimasu.

C Formal (Client/Boss)

お誘いいただきありがとうございます。せっかくですが、本日は先約がありまして。
またぜひお声がけいただけますと幸いです。
Osasoi itadaki arigatou gozaimasu. Sekkaku desu ga, honjitsu wa senyaku ga arimashite. Mata zehi okogake itadakemasu to saiwai desu.

💡 Rule of thumb

Acknowledging the kindness of the invitation with "Arigatou" or "Sekkaku desu ga" (It's a shame, but...) is essential before declining. Use "Mata no kikai" (another opportunity) to leave the door open.

03 Saying No

Deadline

Situation

You are asked to finish a task by tomorrow, but it is physically impossible.

Intention (what you mean)

That deadline is too tight. If Friday is okay, I can deliver high quality.

⚠ What NOT to say (too direct)

無理です。もっと時間が必要です。
Impossible. I need more time.

A Casual (Peer)

明日まではちょっと厳しいかも。金曜まで待ってもらえたら助かる！
Ashita made wa chotto kibishii kamo. Kinyou made matte moraetara tasukaru!

B Work-Safe (Standard)

明日までは少し厳しいです。金曜日までお時間をいただけないでしょうか。
Ashita made wa sukoshi kibishii desu. Kinyoubi made ojikan wo itadakenai deshou ka.

C Formal (Client/Boss)

恐縮ですが、明日までの納品は少々厳しい状況です。金曜日までお時間をいただけますと幸いです。
Kyoushuku desu ga, ashita made no nouhin wa shoushou kibishii joukyou desu. Kinyoubi made ojikan wo itadakemasu to saiwai desu.

💡 Rule of thumb

"Kibishii" (strict/tough) is a softer way to say "impossible."
Always ask for the specific extra time you need rather than just saying it's not enough.

04 Saying No

Out of Scope

Situation

Someone asks you for help on a task that isn't your responsibility.

Intention (what you mean)

I'm not the right person for this. Checking with Tanaka-san would be better.

⚠ What NOT to say (too direct)

それは私の仕事じゃありません。他の人に聞いてください。
That's not my job. Ask someone else.

A Casual (Peer)

それ、たぶん自分の担当じゃないかも。田中さんに聞くのが早いと思うよ！
Sore, tabun jibun no tantou janai kamo. Tanaka-san ni kiku no ga hayai to omou yo!

B Work-Safe (Standard)

すみません、それは私の担当外になります。担当の田中さんに確認してもらえますか。
Sumimasen, sore wa watashi no tantougai ni narimasu. Tantou no Tanaka-san ni kakunin shite moraemasu ka.

C Formal (Client/Boss)

恐れ入りますが、そちらは私の担当外となります。担当の田中が適切かと思いますので、ご確認いただけますでしょうか。
Osoreirimasu ga, sochira wa watashi no tantougai to narimasu. Tantou no Tanaka ga tekisetsu ka to omoimasu node, gokakunin itadakemasu deshou ka.

💡 Rule of thumb

Avoid saying "not my job" directly. Use "Tantougai" (outside of my charge) and pivot to being helpful by pointing them to the correct person.

05 Saying No

Risk

Situation

A coworker proposes a plan that you think is risky or against policy.

Intention (what you mean)

I'm concerned about the risk. Can we consider a safer option?

⚠ What NOT to say (too direct)

それは間違いです。リスクが高すぎます。
That's wrong. It's too risky.

A Casual (Peer)

それ、ちょっとリスク高くない？別のやり方も考えたほうがいいかも。
Sore, chotto risuku takakunai? Betsu no yarikata mo kangaeta hou ga ii kamo.

B Work-Safe (Standard)

その方法は少しリスクがありそうです。別の案も検討しませんか。
Sono houhou wa sukoshi risuku ga arisou desu. Betsu no an mo kentou shimasen ka.

C Formal (Client/Boss)

恐れ入りますが、その進め方ですとリスクが懸念されます。代替案の相談をさせていただきますでしょうか。
Osoreirimasu ga, sono susumekata desu to risuku ga kenen saremasu. Daitaian no soudan wo sasete itadakemasu deshou ka.

💡 Rule of thumb

Focus on the plan's risk, not the person's mistake.
Use "Kenen saremasu" (it is a concern) to sound professional and objective.

You've just read 5 of 30.

The Essential 30 covers the other 25 work situations that quietly make foreigners sound rude in Japanese, across 6 categories:

- Saying No: decline tasks, invites, tight deadlines
- Requests: ask for reviews, files, a few minutes, time off
- Apologies: running late, mistakes, late replies, missed deadlines
- Follow-ups: chase a reply, confirm decisions & next steps
- Opinions: disagree, raise a concern, propose alternatives
- Daily / Chat: greetings, gratitude, small talk, signing off

Each one: what NOT to say, plus copy-paste Japanese at 3 politeness levels (Casual / Work-Safe / Formal) with romaji.

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